THE RED LIST

Consumer Rising — 10 ingredients worth putting back on the shelf

PUT IT BACK

Artificial Food Dyes

Look for: Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6, Red 3, Blue 1, Allura Red, Tartrazine, FD&C; colors

Colors added to make candy, drinks, and cereal look fun — warning-labeled or restricted in some countries, still everywhere in the US.

PUT IT BACK

High Fructose Corn Syrup

Look for: HFCS, HFCS-55, Glucose-fructose syrup, Isoglucose

The cheap liquid sweetener in most American sodas — also hiding in bread, ketchup, and salad dressing.

PUT IT BACK

Partially Hydrogenated Oils

Look for: PHOs, Partially hydrogenated soybean oil, Shortening (some)

The main source of artificial trans fat. The FDA told industry to remove them by 2020, but label loopholes let traces remain.

PUT IT BACK

Brominated Vegetable Oil (BVO)

Look for: BVO, E443

Kept citrus flavor mixed in some sodas and sports drinks — the FDA revoked its food authorization in 2024.

PUT IT BACK

Potassium Bromate

Look for: Bromated flour, E924

Makes bread rise higher and look whiter. Removed from EU food years ago — still allowed in the US.

PUT IT BACK

Sodium Nitrite & Sodium Nitrate

Look for: Sodium Nitrite, Sodium Nitrate, E250, E251, celery powder

Keeps bacon pink and hot dogs shelf-stable — a real food-safety job, but nitrite can form nitrosamines in the body.

PUT IT BACK

BHA

Look for: Butylated hydroxyanisole, E320

Keeps fats in chips, cereal, and gum from going stale. Listed as ‘reasonably anticipated to be a human carcinogen’ in the US.

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BHT

Look for: BHT, Butylated hydroxytoluene, E321

Keeps cereals and snack fats from going rancid. On EWG’s Dirty Dozen additives list as a precaution.

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TBHQ

Look for: TBHQ, Tertiary butylhydroquinone, E319

Keeps crackers and baked goods from going rancid — found in thousands of packaged foods, with almost no human safety data.

PUT IT BACK

Propyl Gallate

Look for: Propyl gallate, E310

Protects fats in meat products and candy, usually teamed with BHA and BHT. EWG flags it as an ingredient of concern.